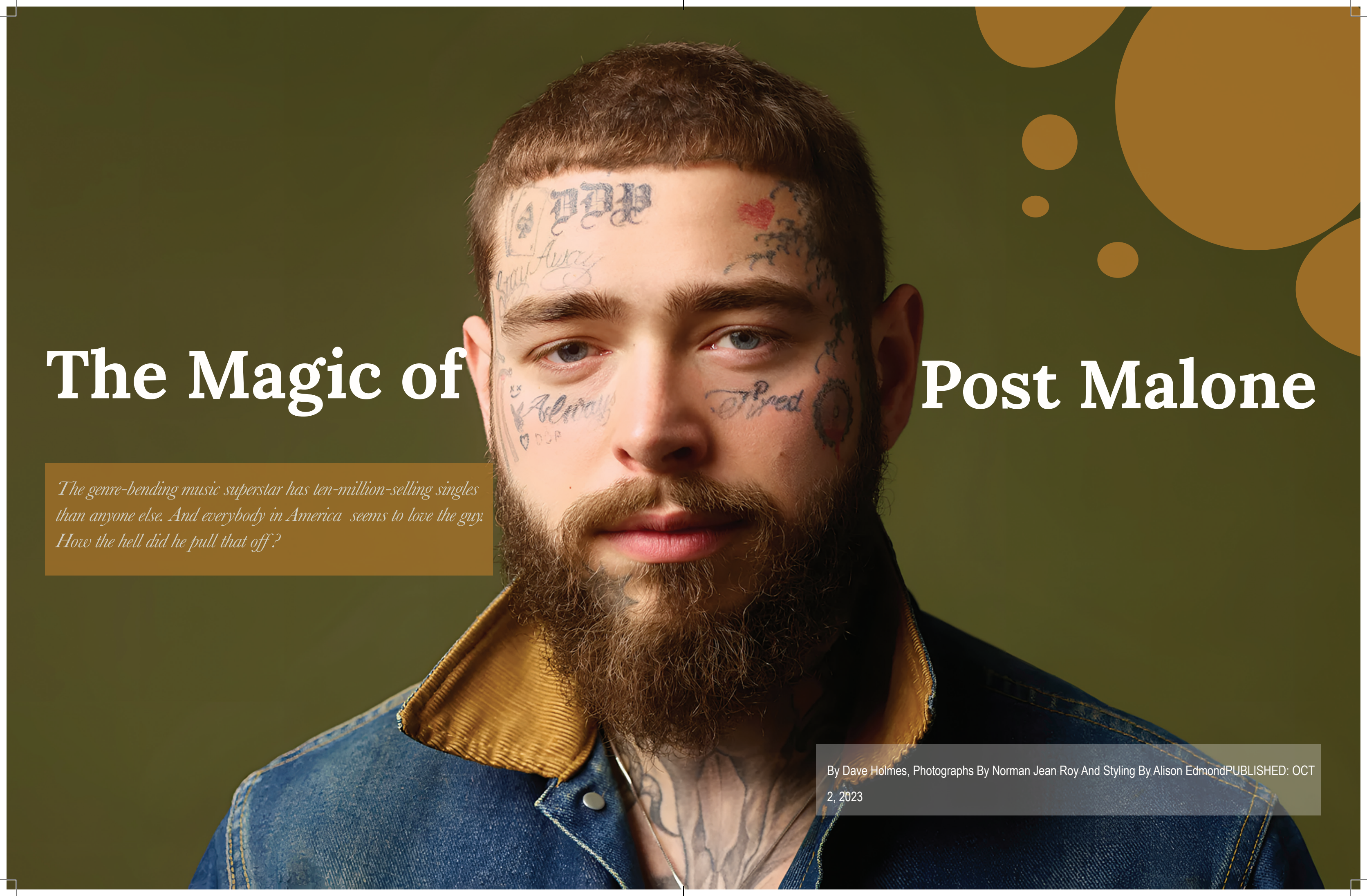


A close-up portrait of Post Malone. He has a full, dark beard and mustache. His face is covered in various tattoos, including a large 'PMP' on his forehead, a red heart on his right forehead, and 'Always' on his left cheek. He is wearing a blue denim jacket over a mustard-colored collared shirt. The background is a dark olive green with several large, overlapping gold circles in the upper right corner.

The Magic of Post Malone

The genre-bending music superstar has ten-million-selling singles than anyone else. And everybody in America seems to love the guy. How the hell did he pull that off?

By Dave Holmes, Photographs By Norman Jean Roy And Styling By Alison EdmondPUBLISHED: OCT 2, 2023

“The what now?” he explains: “It’s like a hydraulic thing. You press on the pedal and it smashes metal down, so it’s good for flattening out raw steel and shit like that. Then you take it to the anvil.” Malone lights up when he talks about this stuff, like an energetic twelve-year-old with a new favorite toy and somewhere between five and eight Bud Lights in him. “There’s nothing better than a cold beer, some good music, and just a hot-ass piece of metal and you’re fucking whaling on it.” Other responsibilities are taking him away from it at the moment, but it’s there. *“I got this beautiful one-and-a-half-ton anvil to forge on, and we’re getting the power hammer and all that stuff.”* When I interrupt him with the very professional question “The what now?” he explains: “It’s like a hydraulic thing. You press on the pedal and it smashes metal down, so it’s good for flattening out raw steel and shit like that. Then you take it to the anvil.” Malone lights up when he talks about this stuff, like an energetic twelve-year-old with a new favorite toy and somewhere between five and eight Bud Lights in

There are more than eight billion people on planet earth, and very few of them can remain relatable while they’re telling you about the time the diamond fell out of their mouth. Not just relatable, likable. Your heart breaks when you hear how he hungrily bit into a Chicken McNugget that night in Rome, and how he just knew he’d lost that \$600,000 fang. It hardly matters that the story has already been spoiled. The two massive, real-ass jewels are right there on his canines where they belong; a happy ending is a sure thing. But still: “I had the left one in my hand, and I dropped it right into the sink hole,” he says. (Under normal circumstances, you’d correct him and say, “Drain,” but you don’t, because the guy is on a roll.) “I’m like, ‘Fuck, man, I’m going to have to go into the ancient Roman sewers.’” You find yourself rooting for this guy to locate the twelve-carat gem that a team of dentists and jewelers shaped and polished and drilled into his teeth. You applaud his ingenuity when he tells you about how he rigged up a scooping device with a pair of pliers and a plastic takeout-pizza tripod; you relax a little when he retrieves it; you feel his victory when a Roman dentista gets it re-embedded. *He did it!* Other responsibilities are taking him away from it at the moment, but Other responsibilities are taking him away from it at the moment, but it’s there. “I got this beautiful one-and-a-half-ton anvil to forge on, and we’re getting the power hammer and all that stuff.” When I interrupt him with the very professional question “The what now?” he explains: *“It’s like a hydraulic thing. You press on the pedal and it smashes metal down, so it’s good for flattening out raw steel and shit like that.* Then you take it to the anvil.” Malone lights up when he talks about this stuff, like an energetic twelve-year-old with a new favorite toy and somewhere between five and eight Bud Lights in him. “There’s nothing better than a cold beer, some good music, and just a hot-ass piece of metal and you’re fucking whaling on it.” there. “I got this beautiful one-and-a-half-ton anvil to forge on, and we’re getting the power hammer and all that stuff.” When I him. “There’s nothing better than a cold beer, some good music, and just a hot-ass piece of metal and you’re fucking whaling on it.”

“I just am MYSELF, and I just want to go and ROCK’N’ROLL.”

NORMAN JEAN ROY

LAURENT BY ANTHONY VACCARELLO; KILT BY RHUDE; PENDANT BY TIFFANY & CO.; CUSTOM ROLEX WATCH, CUBAN LINK BRACELET, DIAMOND RING, AND EMERALD RING BY THE CROWN COLLECTION.



“The goal is to be a kid, man. As long as you can.”

You know what? I’m going to try and do something different and just kind of put My own spin on shit.’ I’m happy now, and I’m so grateful, and I’m just doing the best I can.”

Which brings us back to the fundamental question of exactly what world he’s in now, a question I’m no closer to answering after a nearly two-hour show. What I can say for sure is that he puts it all out there. The show has moments that are acoustic and vulnerable, moments that are trap-beats-y and boastful, moments when the string section really gets to let loose. He wails and he dances, and he hits that tremolo and plays that guitar and acts a fool onstage just like a rock star. He says “fucking” so much that it may not actually be a swear word anymore. He says, “Please buy a T-shirt so I can send my kid to college,” and you forget for a second that in between the brain and the microphone, those words

passed by \$1.2 million worth of elective dental- diamond work. “Thank you so very fuckin’ much,” he says, a million times before the final time, and then it’s over and he’s backstage for the after-party. I hang out for a little bit, but there are twice as many people as there were before, the special-ops guys have had a couple more hours’ worth of Tito’s, a middle-aged Russian guy in hot-pink sneakers has hit the joint-rolling station and is staring through me, and Malone has a room to work. When the guy I’m talking to tells me, “I’m actually kind of a controversial figure in the world of CrossFit,” I take it as the exit cue that it is.

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That’s what pop music is now. That’s what the future sounds like.



off four different dishes and serve them up as a whole new recipe. But why wouldn’t he? Malone was born in 1995, on the actual goddamn Fourth of July. That means he wasn’t even eight when the iTunes Music Store opened, and every song he could think of was one frictionless, ninety- nine-cent click away. He turned sixteen in July 2011, when Spotify launched in the United States and he didn’t have to pay by the song anymore. By the time he was out of high school, SoundCloud was turning bedroom hip-hop artists like Lil Peep and XXXTentacion into mainstream pop stars. So if Malone’s music is a little bit country and a little bit hip-hop and—I swear, there are moments on Austin that sound like this—a little bit eighties adult contemporary, if he can collaborate with Bad Bunny and Lorde and Noah Kahan, well, that’s what you should expect from a twenty-eight-year-old.